How to use this sheet

At-Home-While-Away Checklist · the home side of a calmer trip, in two modes.

Do the door walk the night before

Ticks on the door walk get done twice: once the night before and once on leave day. Both crossings take 10 minutes each and the twice version is the one that actually catches things.

Hand the list to a helper

The "while you're away" rows ask very little — a neighbor with a curb day and a walk-by is plenty. Print a copy for them with only their rows highlighted; being asked for less makes more people say yes.

The return rows matter most

Nobody books the re-entry. Water back to full flow, thermostat back to normal, one easy dinner, and a laundry-free first hour — this stops your calm metabolism from turning arrivals into chores.

Shred the personal pages

Anything with contact info or gate codes gets shredded after the trip. Same rule as the medications card: nothing personal lingers in a drawer for years.

At-Home-While-Away Checklist

Trips feel calmer when home behaves itself while you're gone. Two phases: before you walk out, and when you're back.

Before walking out the door

✓	TASK	WHO / NOTES
☐	Pet sitter / kennel confirmed and booked	
☐	Plants watered; watering drinks for the trip ready	
☐	Trash & recycling out; perishables thrown out	
☐	Water taps and all doors, windows, garage checked	
☐	Thermostat set; water heater set (some heat vs none)	
☐	Mail: hold the mail and hold package deliveries	
☐	Security: lights on timers or smart lights scheduled	
☐	Car: parked, locked, and plugged in if electric	
☐	Valuables hidden & safe; laptop locked away	
☐	Neighbor contact copy: gate codes, alarm notes	
☐	Cards and wallet: on your person, never packed deep	
☐	Final door lock check (twice works every time)	

While you're away — the minimal involvement plan

✓	ASK A HELPER	HOW OFTEN
☐	Take bins to the curb and back	
☐	Quick walk-by so it feels lived-in	
☐	Water anything surprisingly thirsty	
☐	Pick up any shocking deliveries	
☐	Give an emergency contact a slip of keys	

Back-home re-entry (the step everyone skips)

✓	TASK	NOTES
☐	Come home to a calm space — no surprise cleanup before sitting down	
☐	Packages, deliveries, and outside stuff brought in	
☐	Thermostat and water heater back on	
☐	Grab-first laundry, then a real meal: fix the re-entry dinner plan	
☐	Thank the pet sitter / helpers	
☐	Close the trip: shred the meds card copy, end the checklist	

Holdmail tip

A pile of visible mail is the number one giveaway nobody's home. Holdmail services exist in most countries — book them before travel day, and note the start & end dates here: ____ to ____

Dark house fix

Lamps on timers, one evening, one hallway. Mirrored windows in a dark house at 2 a.m. scream "everything's outside." Timers solve two visibility and four presence cues cheaply.